Forming Interrogative Sentences

In French, there are different ways to ask questions. Some are more formal, and some are more casual.

5 Methods of Forming Questions

1. Raising Intonation (Informal)
2. Using "Est-ce que" (Common)
3. Inversion (Formal)
4. Adding a Question Tag (Informal)
5. Using Interrogative Words

1. Raising Intonation (Informal)

The simplest way to form a question in spoken French is to use the same word order as a statement but **raise your intonation** at the end.

- Statement: Tu parles français. *(You speak French.)*
- Question: Tu parles français ? *(Do you speak French?)*

- Statement: Il vient demain. *(He is coming tomorrow.)*
- Question: Il vient demain ? *(Is he coming tomorrow?)*

2. Using "Est-ce que" (Common)

"Est-ce que" is a common way to form questions in French. It is placed **at the beginning of the sentence** without changing the word order.

Structure: **Est-ce que** + subject + verb + ... ?

- Statement: Tu parles français. *(You speak French.)*
- Question: **Est-ce que** tu parles français ? *(Do you speak French?)*

- Statement: Il vient demain. *(He is coming tomorrow.)*
- Question: **Est-ce qu'**il vient demain ? *(Is he coming tomorrow?)*

3. Inversion (Formal)

Inversion is a more formal method of forming questions. It involves **inverting the subject and the verb**.

Structure: **Verb** + **subject** + ... ?

- Statement: Tu parles français. *(You speak French.)*
- Question: **Parles-tu** français ? *(Do you speak French?)*

- Statement: Il vient demain. *(He is coming tomorrow.)*
- Question: **Vient-il** demain ? *(Is he coming tomorrow?)*

When the verb ends in a vowel and the subject pronoun begins with a vowel, a "**t**" is added for ease of pronunciation.

- A-**t**-il fini ? *(Has he finished?)*

4. Adding a Question Tag (Informal)

In informal spoken French, adding a question tag **at the end of a statement** can turn it into a question. Common question tags include "**n'est-ce pas ?**" (isn't it?) and "**d'accord ?**" (okay?).

Structure: Statement + **question tag** ?

- Statement: Tu parles français. *(You speak French.)*

- Question: Tu parles français, **n'est-ce pas ?** *(You speak French, don't you?)*

- Statement: Il vient demain. *(He is coming tomorrow.)*
- Question: Il vient demain, **d'accord ?** *(He is coming tomorrow, okay?)*

5. Using Interrogative Words

Interrogative words (see next lesson) are used to ask **specific types of questions**. They can be used with any of the above methods.

- **Qui** est-ce ? *(Who is it?)*
- **Qu'**est-ce que tu fais ? *(What are you doing?)*
- **Que** fais-tu ? *(What are you doing?)*
- **Où** habites-tu ? *(Where do you live?)*

